Indians—patronized the elite religions and commissioned big religious works and monuments that have survived far better than the localized deities and shrines of folk religions, which were often made from perishable materials. Indeed, it's quite likely that back then most people in the subcontinent fell outside dominant scripture-based religions, and whose animism and polytheism only occasionally included a mishmash of ideas and practices from the politically dominant religions of the day. Well into the colonial era, a great many Indians—worshipping rivers, animals, trees, spirits, saints, matas and other hyperlocal deities—subscribed to beliefs and practices that only had small overlaps with the doctrinal niceties, elite gods and customs of Vedic-Dharmic religions.

Nonetheless, the accounts of the Chinese are invaluable for opening new windows into our past that continue to inform and enchant us, and for providing us the evidence we need to resist the rewriting of history to suit narrow political ends.